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Graduate Admissions Committee
Department of Communications and New Media, National University of Singapore

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**Re: PhD in Communications and New Media, August 2027 intake (NUS Research Scholarship)**

Dear Committee members,

In my MSc I built a system to read public reaction to economic policy, and only later found that it had silently thrown away every comment written in Urdu or Hindi. By then I had spent six years building data systems for companies, and I had never once been asked whether the numbers were right for the people behind them. That question now runs through my start-up, my industry work and my research, and it is why I am applying to CNM. My proposal asks whether LLM-labelled political opinion in Pakistan and India means the same thing across Urdu script, Roman Urdu, English and Hinglish, and across YouTube and Facebook comments on the same stories, and whether our conclusions change when it does not.

**Where it started.** I began as a computer science student at FAST in Karachi, taking web-data orders on Fiverr, and completed more than 300 projects as a Level 2 seller while helping other students into freelance work. That taught me where online data comes from and how messy it is before anyone models it. At Dubizzle Labs (2022 to 2024), the company behind marketplaces across the Middle East, I designed its first web-data architecture, serving six products across nine countries in English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi. I led a team of three engineers and was promoted twice. It was there I first saw that the same thing is written, and counted, differently in different languages and markets.

**The vision: helping governments hear people.** In 2023 protests over electricity bills spread across Pakistan. My Chevening Scholarship proposal grew from that: a cross-platform system that would let public bodies read public reaction before such decisions, not after. As a Chevening Scholar I took an MSc in Data Analytics at the University of Portsmouth and graduated with Distinction (master's project 78/100). My dissertation built a small version of the idea, 255,446 comments on UK economic policy from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, and taught me its hardest lesson: my classifier had been checked against labels produced by a lexicon, so its apparent accuracy measured agreement, not truth.

**Seeing the problem at scale.** Since December 2024 I have worked for M+C Saatchi Fluency, London, building social listening and AI pipelines for global brands in consumer health, automotive, e-commerce and sport, and supporting work for UK government. I built a year-long discourse study of more than 100,000 posts tagged by an LLM against a codebook that humans signed off, with every prompt version tracked; a fleet of more than 60 forum crawlers that AI agents repair, but only after their fixes pass verification; and multilingual emotion coding across twelve platforms. Since December 2025 I have also worked as a data engineer at CXG in Dubai, collecting and analysing product data for global fashion brands such as Prada, where the same attribute is written differently in every region and language. Across five companies the lesson was the same: the people who act on these numbers rarely see how fragile they are.

**Building it myself: Artemis AI.** In February 2025 I co-founded Artemis AI, a UK start-up building an AI advisor that reads creators' and small businesses' Facebook and Instagram pages and tells them what their audience is saying and what to do next. As CTO I lead the architecture and evaluation of an eight-person team's system: 48 models across text, image, video, time series, crisis detection and a page network built with community detection, about ten of them running weekly over 3.4 million public comments, with a beta launch on 15 December 2026. It reads Meta data read-only and stores no commenter identities. Building it taught me that the hardest problem is not modelling but trust. Our own accuracy tracker had to admit that agreement between models is not accuracy, a problem now documented at scale (Kim et al. 2025), and dialect, banter and non-English text are where the models fail first. The problem from my MSc was live inside my own product.

**From lesson to research.** I turned that lesson into a preprint with my supervisor, Dr Ella Haig, *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv:2610.16757): a protocol for testing whether the platform acts as a source of measurement error, with a known-truth simulation showing how pooling misleads when the platform mix shifts. It is not peer reviewed and has not yet been applied to real data. Preparing this application also showed me where my contribution lies: model and prompt effects are already well documented (Baumann et al. 2025; Messing

2026), so the PhD would add the South Asian script and platform test, with designs that hold the message fixed, and a Roman Urdu political-stance gold set, which I have not found in existing work.

**Why CNM.** CNM is a communication department doing computational work on Asian publics, and that is the training I lack. Dr Subhayan Mukerjee's work with Yang and Peng shows that the link between engagement metrics and news production depends on the platform; my second study asks the same of how audience reaction under the same stories is measured. Dr Zening Duan's work on how operationalisation changes what a text measure captures is the basis for my first study on scripts. I have proposed Dr Mukerjee as advisor and Dr Duan as co-supervisor, and the work of Associate Professors Taberez Neyazi and Kokil Jaidka on South Asian political communication also informs the design.

**Why a PhD, and why now.** Industry keeps giving me questions it cannot answer: whether a negative comment means the same thing on two platforms, whether a model reads Roman Urdu fairly, whether agreement between models is accuracy. A product ships by Friday; nobody pays for a gold set until the numbers are already wrong. I want four years to answer these questions properly, then carry the answers back into Artemis and, as I promised in my Chevening application, into how public bodies in Pakistan read the public.

**What I do not yet bring, and what I offer.** I have no peer-reviewed publication yet, and my training in communication theory and causal inference is limited; CNM's core modules are a main reason I am applying. I can offer nearly eight years of hands-on data work, Urdu and Hindi for codebook design, and support for teaching in social media analytics through the Graduate Assistantship Programme.

**Practicalities.** Both my degrees were taught in English, and I am applying for the NUS Research Scholarship. My referees are Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, University of Portsmouth, my dissertation supervisor and co-author, and Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, University of Portsmouth, who taught and assessed me on the MSc. Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely,
**Asad Ikram**